

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Nature of Religious Language - Solved Practice Workbook

Standalone solved practice workbook · 32 hard MCQs · 14 verified PYQs · 6 original Mains models

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Nature of Religious Language - Solved Practice Workbook	3
How to use this workbook	3
Workbook inventory	3
Marking, terminology and answer discipline	3
Self-scoring bands	3
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	3
CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 24	3
REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 8	17
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	22
VERIFIED PYQS - 14 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS	22
ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE - 6 MODELS	29
Question-shaped timed-paper compression plan	32
Independence note	32

Nature of Religious Language - Solved Practice Workbook

Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion · Topic 10 Standalone workbook: complete practice without dependence on the learning-session text.

How to use this workbook

Attempt every item before reading its key. Correct positions were independently randomised and balanced: exactly eight A, eight B, eight C and eight D, with no adjacent repeat, no predictable rotation and no repeated four-answer sequence. Every option has a question-specific explanation; every question has a unique examiner trap.

Workbook inventory

Part	Count
Core hard MCQs	24
Remedial MCQs	8
Option-specific explanations	128
Unique examiner traps	32
Verified PYQs, fully solved	14
Original solved Mains models	6 (2 x 10, 2 x 15, 2 x 20)

Marking, terminology and answer discipline

- Word ceilings: 10 marks - 150 words; 15 marks - 250 words; 20 marks - 350 words.
- Every model follows **claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification**.
- English concept first; Sanskrit/Pali terms follow immediately in accurate transliteration.
- Verified questions are exact reproductions; solutions are independent learner practice, never official keys.

Self-scoring bands

Band	MCQs	Written-answer signature
Weak	0-14	HOW and WHETHER merged; analogy/symbol/non-cognition treated as synonyms
Average	15-20	Core thinkers named but mechanisms and qualifications thin
Good	21-25	Two axes, Aquinas, Tillich, Braithwaite and Advaita correctly distinguished
Strong	26-29	Scotus, Maimonides, falsification, speech acts and Indian controls used
Top	30-32	Spectrum, contested attributions, mysticism route and pluralism bridge precise

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 24

MCQ 1. Which formulation best distinguishes the two main axes in the study of religious language?

A. HOW asks whether God exists; WHETHER asks which religion is oldest, in every context. B. HOW concerns only ritual; WHETHER concerns only mysticism, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference. C. HOW is cognitive; WHETHER is necessarily non-cognitive, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. D. HOW asks how transcendent predicates signify; WHETHER asks whether utterances are truth-apt.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "HOW asks whether God exists; WHETHER asks which religion is oldest, in every context.". It fails the controlling distinction. Univocity, equivocity, analogy, symbol, negation and *lakṣaṇā* answer the semantic HOW question. Cognitivism, moral-conative theories, *bliks*, meaning-as-use and verificationism address WHETHER religious utterances state truths. A theory may cross the axes: Tillich can offer symbolic mode while retaining symbolic realism; a performative may carry assertoric presuppositions.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "HOW concerns only ritual; WHETHER concerns only mysticism, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference.". It fails the controlling distinction. Univocity, equivocity, analogy, symbol, negation and *lakṣaṇā* answer the semantic HOW question. Cognitivism, moral-conative theories, *bliks*, meaning-as-use and verificationism address WHETHER religious utterances state truths. A theory may cross the axes: Tillich can offer symbolic mode while retaining symbolic realism; a performative may carry assertoric presuppositions.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "HOW is cognitive; WHETHER is necessarily non-cognitive, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. Univocity, equivocity, analogy, symbol, negation and *lakṣaṇā* answer the semantic HOW question. Cognitivism, moral-conative theories, *bliks*, meaning-as-use and verificationism address WHETHER religious utterances state truths. A theory may cross the axes: Tillich can offer symbolic mode while retaining symbolic realism; a performative may carry assertoric presuppositions.
- **D:** Correct: Univocity, equivocity, analogy, symbol, negation and *lakṣaṇā* answer the semantic HOW question. Cognitivism, moral-conative theories, *bliks*, meaning-as-use and verificationism address WHETHER religious utterances state truths. A theory may cross the axes: Tillich can offer symbolic mode while retaining symbolic realism; a performative may carry assertoric presuppositions.

Examiner trap 1: Separate HOW from WHETHER; symbolic mode does not settle truth-aptness.

MCQ 2. Aquinas' analogy of proportionality most nearly means that:

A. goodness belongs to God according to the divine mode as it belongs to creatures according to theirs. B. "Good" has wholly unrelated meanings for God and creatures, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment. C. divine goodness is only a metaphor generated by human emotion, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. D. God is called good only because believers choose a moral policy, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Proportionality compares relations across distinct modes of being; it neither asserts univocal sameness nor equivocal disconnection. Attribution instead orders secondary uses to a primary source. The metaphysical ground is causal participation: an effect resembles its cause without possessing perfection in the same finite manner.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "'Good' has wholly unrelated meanings for God and creatures, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment.". It fails the controlling distinction. Proportionality compares relations across distinct modes of being; it neither asserts univocal sameness nor equivocal disconnection. Attribution instead orders secondary uses to a primary source. The metaphysical ground is causal participation: an effect resembles its cause without possessing perfection in the same finite manner.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "divine goodness is only a metaphor generated by human emotion, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. Proportionality compares relations across distinct modes of being; it neither asserts univocal sameness nor

equivocal disconnection. Attribution instead orders secondary uses to a primary source. The metaphysical ground is causal participation: an effect resembles its cause without possessing perfection in the same finite manner.

- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "God is called good only because believers choose a moral policy, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. Proportionality compares relations across distinct modes of being; it neither asserts univocal sameness nor equivocal disconnection. Attribution instead orders secondary uses to a primary source. The metaphysical ground is causal participation: an effect resembles its cause without possessing perfection in the same finite manner.

Examiner trap 2: Attribution/proportionality is later Thomist, especially Cajetanian, systematisation.

MCQ 3. In Aquinas' account, what is the function of the distinction between *res significata* and *modus significandi*?

A. It converts every divine predicate into a liturgical command, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment. B. It makes God and creatures ontologically members of one genus, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. C. It permits the perfection signified to apply truly while treating the creaturely manner of signifying as inadequate. D. It denies that perfection-terms signify anything of God, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, in every context.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "It converts every divine predicate into a liturgical command, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment.". It fails the controlling distinction. The *res significata*-for example goodness-can be affirmed of God, while the *modus significandi* reflects finite creaturely cognition and therefore cannot capture God's mode of possession. This technical pair is how Aquinas protects realism without crude anthropomorphism.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "It makes God and creatures ontologically members of one genus, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. The *res significata*-for example goodness-can be affirmed of God, while the *modus significandi* reflects finite creaturely cognition and therefore cannot capture God's mode of possession. This technical pair is how Aquinas protects realism without crude anthropomorphism.
- **C:** Correct: The *res significata*-for example goodness-can be affirmed of God, while the *modus significandi* reflects finite creaturely cognition and therefore cannot capture God's mode of possession. This technical pair is how Aquinas protects realism without crude anthropomorphism.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "It denies that perfection-terms signify anything of God, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, in every context.". It fails the controlling distinction. The *res significata*-for example goodness-can be affirmed of God, while the *modus significandi* reflects finite creaturely cognition and therefore cannot capture God's mode of possession. This technical pair is how Aquinas protects realism without crude anthropomorphism.

Examiner trap 3: Do not reduce Aquinas to cause-only language; *res significata* applies essentially and eminently.

MCQ 4. Maimonides permits which form of discourse about God most characteristically?

A. Only univocal positive predicates shared with creatures, in every context. B. Purely fictional stories with no theological intent, under the theory's own terms. C. Symbols understood as identical with their divine referent, for every form of religious discourse. D. Negations and attributes of action rather than positive essential attributes, while preserving its other speech functions.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Only univocal positive predicates shared with creatures, in every context.". It fails the controlling distinction. In *Guide for the Perplexed* I.50-60, Maimonides protects divine simplicity and transcendence: one may deny ignorance or describe God as merciful from divine action, without positing a creature-like essential quality. The standard objection is vacuity-unlimited negation may fail to distinguish God from nothing.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Purely fictional stories with no theological intent, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. In *Guide for the Perplexed* I.50-60, Maimonides protects divine simplicity and transcendence: one may deny ignorance or describe God as merciful from divine action, without positing a creature-like essential quality. The standard objection is vacuity-unlimited negation may fail to distinguish God from nothing.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "Symbols understood as identical with their divine referent, for every form of religious discourse.". It fails the controlling distinction. In *Guide for the Perplexed* I.50-60, Maimonides protects divine simplicity and transcendence: one may deny ignorance or describe God as merciful from divine action, without positing a creature-like essential quality. The standard objection is vacuity-unlimited negation may fail to distinguish God from nothing.
- **D:** Correct: In *Guide for the Perplexed* I.50-60, Maimonides protects divine simplicity and transcendence: one may deny ignorance or describe God as merciful from divine action, without positing a creature-like essential quality. The standard objection is vacuity-unlimited negation may fail to distinguish God from nothing.

Examiner trap 4: Maimonides permits negations and attributes of action, not creaturely positive essence.

MCQ 5. What most decisively distinguishes a Tillichian symbol from a sign?

A. A symbol is always linguistic whereas a sign is always visual, in every context. B. A symbol participates in what it indicates and opens levels of reality and self, under the stated distinction. C. A symbol has one fixed conventional meaning and cannot die, for every form of religious discourse. D. A symbol is merely an inaccurate literal statement, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "A symbol is always linguistic whereas a sign is always visual, in every context.". It fails the controlling distinction. A sign points by convention and is replaceable; a symbol participates, discloses, transforms, arises collectively and may grow or die. Calling symbol a mere sign destroys Tillich's mechanism. Symbolic language is non-literal, but it need not be non-cognitive or arbitrary.
- **B:** Correct: A sign points by convention and is replaceable; a symbol participates, discloses, transforms, arises collectively and may grow or die. Calling symbol a mere sign destroys Tillich's mechanism. Symbolic language is non-literal, but it need not be non-cognitive or arbitrary.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "A symbol has one fixed conventional meaning and cannot die, for every form of religious discourse.". It fails the controlling distinction. A sign points by convention and is replaceable; a symbol participates, discloses, transforms, arises collectively and may grow or die. Calling symbol a mere sign destroys Tillich's mechanism. Symbolic language is non-literal, but it need not be non-cognitive or arbitrary.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "A symbol is merely an inaccurate literal statement, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. A sign points by convention and is replaceable; a symbol participates, discloses, transforms, arises collectively and may grow or die. Calling symbol a mere sign destroys Tillich's mechanism. Symbolic language is non-literal, but it need not be non-cognitive or arbitrary.

Examiner trap 5: Tillichian symbol participates and discloses; a conventional pointer is only a sign.

MCQ 6. Ian Ramsey's "model and qualifier" account explains religious language by claiming that:

A. an ordinary model is stretched by a qualifier until a disclosure situation occurs, while preserving its other speech functions. B. religious models are univocal scientific descriptions, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike. C. models are dispensable once a creed is memorised, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike. D. qualifiers cancel all ordinary content, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: "Father," "cause" or "good" supplies a model; "heavenly," "first" or "infinitely" qualifies and develops it until the "penny drops." Ramsey explains continuity with ordinary speech without reducing religious use either to literal identity or complete equivocation.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "religious models are univocal scientific descriptions, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. "Father," "cause" or "good" supplies a model; "heavenly," "first" or "infinitely" qualifies and develops it until the "penny drops." Ramsey explains continuity with ordinary speech without reducing religious use either to literal identity or complete equivocation.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "models are dispensable once a creed is memorised, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. "Father," "cause" or "good" supplies a model; "heavenly," "first" or "infinitely" qualifies and develops it until the "penny drops." Ramsey explains continuity with ordinary speech without reducing religious use either to literal identity or complete equivocation.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "qualifiers cancel all ordinary content, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. "Father," "cause" or "good" supplies a model; "heavenly," "first" or "infinitely" qualifies and develops it until the "penny drops." Ramsey explains continuity with ordinary speech without reducing religious use either to literal identity or complete equivocation.

Examiner trap 6: Ramsey stretches an ordinary model by a qualifier; he does not cancel ordinary meaning.

MCQ 7. Which religious utterance most clearly illustrates Austin's performative analysis?

A. "The temple was built of stone," used as an archaeological report, without qualification. B. "I take refuge in the Buddha," sincerely uttered as an act of commitment, with qualification. C. "Some believers fast," used as a sociological description, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice. D. "The manuscript contains five chapters," used bibliographically, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states ""The temple was built of stone," used as an archaeological report, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. The utterance does not merely report a prior state; under appropriate conditions it performs the act of taking refuge. Austin's constative/performative and illocutionary analysis shows why testing every religious sentence as a detached description is a category mistake.
- **B:** Correct: The utterance does not merely report a prior state; under appropriate conditions it performs the act of taking refuge. Austin's constative/performative and illocutionary analysis shows why testing every religious sentence as a detached description is a category mistake.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states ""Some believers fast," used as a sociological description, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice.". It fails the controlling distinction. The utterance does not merely report a prior state; under appropriate conditions it performs the act of taking refuge. Austin's constative/performative and illocutionary analysis shows why testing every religious sentence as a detached description is a category mistake.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states ""The manuscript contains five chapters," used bibliographically, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. The utterance does not merely report a prior state; under appropriate conditions it performs the act of taking refuge. Austin's constative/performative and illocutionary analysis shows why testing every religious sentence as a

detached description is a category mistake.

Examiner trap 7: A performative enacts a relation under felicity conditions; it is not merely unverifiable.

MCQ 8. Donald Evans' idea of self-involvement is best captured by which claim?

A. Religious utterances are always private sensations, under the theory's own terms. B. Self-involvement proves that religious statements cannot assert anything, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike. C. Their avowal characteristically implicates the speaker in attitudes, relationships and conduct, with qualification. D. Only first-person sentences have religious meaning, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Religious utterances are always private sensations, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. Evans extends speech-act analysis to religion: confession, vow and commitment constitute relations and practical stances. Self-involvement does not by itself eliminate cognitive content; a performative can presuppose assertions and a sentence can be assertoric and commissive together.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Self-involvement proves that religious statements cannot assert anything, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. Evans extends speech-act analysis to religion: confession, vow and commitment constitute relations and practical stances. Self-involvement does not by itself eliminate cognitive content; a performative can presuppose assertions and a sentence can be assertoric and commissive together.
- **C:** Correct: Evans extends speech-act analysis to religion: confession, vow and commitment constitute relations and practical stances. Self-involvement does not by itself eliminate cognitive content; a performative can presuppose assertions and a sentence can be assertoric and commissive together.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "Only first-person sentences have religious meaning, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. Evans extends speech-act analysis to religion: confession, vow and commitment constitute relations and practical stances. Self-involvement does not by itself eliminate cognitive content; a performative can presuppose assertions and a sentence can be assertoric and commissive together.

Examiner trap 8: Self-involvement concerns commitment, not privacy or automatic non-cognitivism.

MCQ 9. A. J. Ayer's challenge to "God exists" rests primarily on the claim that:

A. it is false because evil exists, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice. B. it is neither analytically true nor empirically verifiable and is therefore literally meaningless. C. it expresses a morally admirable *blik*, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. D. it is analogical rather than univocal, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "it is false because evil exists, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice.". It fails the controlling distinction. Ayer's is hostile non-cognitivism, unlike Braithwaite's constructive moral account. Critics argue that the verification criterion is too narrow and faces a self-application problem, since the criterion itself is not straightforwardly analytic or empirically verified.
- **B:** Correct: Ayer's is hostile non-cognitivism, unlike Braithwaite's constructive moral account. Critics argue that the verification criterion is too narrow and faces a self-application problem, since the criterion itself is not straightforwardly analytic or empirically verified.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "it expresses a morally admirable *blik*, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. Ayer's is hostile non-cognitivism, unlike Braithwaite's constructive moral account. Critics argue that the verification criterion is too narrow and faces a self-application problem, since the criterion itself is not straightforwardly analytic or empirically verified.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "it is analogical rather than univocal, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. Ayer's is

hostile non-cognitivism, unlike Braithwaite's constructive moral account. Critics argue that the verification criterion is too narrow and faces a self-application problem, since the criterion itself is not straightforwardly analytic or empirically verified.

Examiner trap 9: Ayer calls God-talk meaningless by his criterion; he does not merely call it false.

MCQ 10. Flew's invisible-gardener parable is designed to ask:

A. what conceivable evidence could count against a religious assertion before qualifications empty it of content, with qualification. B. whether God can be named only negatively, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference. C. whether religious stories improve moral motivation, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification. D. whether symbols arise from collective life, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, in every context.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Flew, adapting John Wisdom, argues that a claim can "die the death of a thousand qualifications" if every counter-instance is absorbed. The target is evidential immunity and loss of falsifiable content, not symbolism or moral function.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "whether God can be named only negatively, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference.". It fails the controlling distinction. Flew, adapting John Wisdom, argues that a claim can "die the death of a thousand qualifications" if every counter-instance is absorbed. The target is evidential immunity and loss of falsifiable content, not symbolism or moral function.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "whether religious stories improve moral motivation, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. Flew, adapting John Wisdom, argues that a claim can "die the death of a thousand qualifications" if every counter-instance is absorbed. The target is evidential immunity and loss of falsifiable content, not symbolism or moral function.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "whether symbols arise from collective life, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, in every context.". It fails the controlling distinction. Flew, adapting John Wisdom, argues that a claim can "die the death of a thousand qualifications" if every counter-instance is absorbed. The target is evidential immunity and loss of falsifiable content, not symbolism or moral function.

Examiner trap 10: Flew asks what counts against the assertion; do not confuse falsification with verification.

MCQ 11. R. M. Hare's response to Flew uses bliks to describe:

A. empirically verified predictions about divine action, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike. B. analogies grounded in causal participation, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment. C. basic, unfalsifiable ways of seeing the world that can still govern life significantly, under the stated distinction. D. liturgical commands unique to Mīmāṃsā, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without qualification.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "empirically verified predictions about divine action, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. Hare's paranoid student illustrates that a *blik* may resist evidence yet profoundly shape conduct. Hare thereby rejects Flew's inference from unfalsifiability to unimportance, but at the cost of giving up ordinary factual assertion.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "analogies grounded in causal participation, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment.". It fails the controlling distinction. Hare's paranoid student illustrates that a *blik* may resist evidence yet profoundly shape conduct. Hare thereby rejects Flew's inference from unfalsifiability to unimportance, but at the cost of giving up ordinary factual assertion.
- **C:** Correct: Hare's paranoid student illustrates that a *blik* may resist evidence yet profoundly shape conduct. Hare thereby rejects Flew's inference from unfalsifiability to unimportance, but at the cost of giving up ordinary factual assertion.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "liturgical commands unique to Mīmāṃsā, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. Hare's paranoid student illustrates that a *blik* may resist evidence yet profoundly shape conduct. Hare thereby rejects Flew's inference from unfalsifiability to unimportance, but at the cost of giving up ordinary factual assertion.

Examiner trap 11: Hare preserves practical importance through a blik but gives up ordinary factual vulnerability.

MCQ 12. Hick's eschatological verification claims that a religious proposition may be:

A. falsifiable now but never verifiable, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike. B. truth-apt now and confirmable at the eschaton, despite lacking present decisive verification, under the stated distinction. C. meaningless now but meaningful after death, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference. D. only a symbol with no possible confirmation, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "falsifiable now but never verifiable, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. Hick's celestial-city parable distinguishes present testability from verification in principle. Travellers may differ about their destination while the journey's end could settle the issue asymmetrically. The account answers Ayer but raises questions about present warrant and falsifiability.
- **B:** Correct: Hick's celestial-city parable distinguishes present testability from verification in principle. Travellers may differ about their destination while the journey's end could settle the issue asymmetrically. The account answers Ayer but raises questions about present warrant and falsifiability.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "meaningless now but meaningful after death, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference.". It fails the controlling distinction. Hick's celestial-city parable distinguishes present testability from verification in principle. Travellers may differ about their destination while the journey's end could settle the issue asymmetrically. The account answers Ayer but raises questions about present warrant and falsifiability.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "only a symbol with no possible confirmation, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. Hick's celestial-city parable distinguishes present testability from verification in principle. Travellers may differ about their destination while the journey's end could settle the issue asymmetrically. The account answers Ayer but raises questions about present warrant and falsifiability.

Examiner trap 12: Hick claims truth-aptness now with possible future confirmation; verification is asymmetrical.

MCQ 13. According to Braithwaite, "God is love" primarily functions as:

A. a declaration of commitment to an agapeistic moral policy sustained by religious stories. B. an analogy of attribution, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. C. a prediction verified at the end of history, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice. D. a literal report of an observable divine property, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Braithwaite preserves religion's practical seriousness while relinquishing metaphysical fact-reporting as primary meaning. His account differs from Ayer's meaninglessness, Hare's world-picture and Wittgensteinian grammar. Its central weakness is reductionism: believers generally intend reference as well as commitment.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "an analogy of attribution, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. Braithwaite preserves religion's practical seriousness while relinquishing metaphysical fact-reporting as primary meaning. His account differs from Ayer's meaninglessness, Hare's world-picture and Wittgensteinian grammar. Its central weakness is reductionism: believers generally intend reference as well as commitment.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "a prediction verified at the end of history, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice.". It fails the controlling distinction. Braithwaite preserves religion's practical seriousness while relinquishing metaphysical fact-reporting as primary meaning. His account differs from Ayer's meaninglessness, Hare's world-picture and Wittgensteinian grammar. Its central weakness is reductionism: believers generally intend reference as well as commitment.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "a literal report of an observable divine property, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. Braithwaite preserves religion's practical seriousness while relinquishing metaphysical fact-reporting as primary meaning. His account differs from Ayer's meaninglessness, Hare's world-picture and Wittgensteinian grammar. Its central weakness is reductionism: believers generally intend reference as well as commitment.

Examiner trap 13: Braithwaite is constructive moral-conative non-cognitivism, not Ayerian elimination.

MCQ 14. Which statement best reflects the Wittgensteinian approach to religious language?

A. Every religious claim is meaningless by verificationist criteria, for every form of religious discourse. B. Every religious sentence expresses the same agapeistic policy, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference. C. Religious grammar is identical to laboratory reporting, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. D. Meaning should be sought in use within a religious language-game and form of life, while preserving its other speech functions.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Every religious claim is meaningless by verificationist criteria, for every form of religious discourse.". It fails the controlling distinction. Prayer, confession or belief in Last Judgement is understood through its role in worship, repentance and orientation. The approach resists decontextualised scientific testing. It can be criticised for fideistic insulation, but it is not equivalent to Ayer or Braithwaite.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Every religious sentence expresses the same agapeistic policy, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference.". It fails the controlling distinction. Prayer, confession or belief in Last Judgement is understood through its role in worship, repentance and orientation. The approach resists decontextualised scientific testing. It can be criticised for fideistic insulation, but it is not equivalent to Ayer or Braithwaite.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "Religious grammar is identical to laboratory reporting, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. Prayer, confession or belief in Last Judgement is understood through its role in worship, repentance and orientation. The approach resists decontextualised scientific testing. It can be criticised for fideistic insulation, but it is not equivalent to Ayer or Braithwaite.

- **D:** Correct: Prayer, confession or belief in Last Judgement is understood through its role in worship, repentance and orientation. The approach resists decontextualised scientific testing. It can be criticised for fideistic insulation, but it is not equivalent to Ayer or Braithwaite.

Examiner trap 14: Wittgensteinian use clarifies grammar; it does not automatically deny truth.

MCQ 15. What qualification is required when discussing D. Z. Phillips?

A. He created Ayer's verification principle, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike. B. He defended Scotus' intrinsic modes, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without qualification. C. He rejected being labelled a non-cognitivist or reductionist and presented his work as clarification of religious grammar, under the stated distinction. D. He reduced all worship to fictionalism, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "He created Ayer's verification principle, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. Phillips is associated with Wittgensteinian philosophy of religion, but reporting him simply as a non-cognitivist is factually unsafe. The interpretive dispute must be stated: attention to internal grammar does not automatically deny truth or reduce religion to attitude.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "He defended Scotus' intrinsic modes, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. Phillips is associated with Wittgensteinian philosophy of religion, but reporting him simply as a non-cognitivist is factually unsafe. The interpretive dispute must be stated: attention to internal grammar does not automatically deny truth or reduce religion to attitude.
- **C:** Correct: Phillips is associated with Wittgensteinian philosophy of religion, but reporting him simply as a non-cognitivist is factually unsafe. The interpretive dispute must be stated: attention to internal grammar does not automatically deny truth or reduce religion to attitude.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "He reduced all worship to fictionalism, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. Phillips is associated with Wittgensteinian philosophy of religion, but reporting him simply as a non-cognitivist is factually unsafe. The interpretive dispute must be stated: attention to internal grammar does not automatically deny truth or reduce religion to attitude.

Examiner trap 15: Phillips rejected simple non-cognitivist/reductionist labels; report the dispute.

MCQ 16. Which analysis best describes a mixed speech-act account?

A. Assertions and performatives can never coexist, under the theory's own terms. B. Every religious utterance is only expressive, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike. C. Cognitive content requires univocal literalism, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment. D. Religious utterances may be assertoric, symbolic, expressive and commissive at once, while preserving its other speech functions.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Assertions and performatives can never coexist, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. "God exists" may assert reality, use analogical or symbolic reference, express trust and commit conduct. Mixed analysis avoids Braithwaite's reductionism without ignoring Austin and Evans. It also prevents the false inference that non-literal predication is necessarily non-cognitive.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Every religious utterance is only expressive, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. "God exists" may assert reality, use analogical or symbolic reference, express trust and commit conduct. Mixed analysis avoids Braithwaite's reductionism without ignoring Austin and Evans. It also prevents the false inference that non-literal predication is necessarily non-cognitive.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "Cognitive content requires univocal literalism, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment.". It fails the controlling distinction. "God exists" may assert reality, use analogical or symbolic reference, express trust and commit conduct. Mixed analysis avoids Braithwaite's reductionism without ignoring Austin and Evans. It also prevents the false inference that non-literal predication is necessarily non-cognitive.
- **D:** Correct: "God exists" may assert reality, use analogical or symbolic reference, express trust and commit conduct. Mixed analysis avoids Braithwaite's reductionism without ignoring Austin and Evans. It also prevents the false inference that non-literal predication is necessarily non-cognitive.

Examiner trap 16: Assertion, symbolism, expression and commitment can coexist in one utterance.

MCQ 17. Which comparison between secular and religious language is most defensible?

A. Secular language is always descriptive and religious language always performative, as the decisive criterion. B. They share ordinary words, but often differ in function, referent, verification, register and self-involvement, with qualification. C. They use completely different vocabularies, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification. D. Religious language violates all ordinary logic, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without qualification.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Secular language is always descriptive and religious language always performative, as the decisive criterion.". It fails the controlling distinction. Religious language is a stretched, tradition-formed use of a common instrument, not a separate language. The comparison is one of typical functions rather than absolute boxes: secular speech also performs, while religious discourse can assert facts.
- **B:** Correct: Religious language is a stretched, tradition-formed use of a common instrument, not a separate language. The comparison is one of typical functions rather than absolute boxes: secular speech also performs, while religious discourse can assert facts.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "They use completely different vocabularies, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. Religious language is a stretched, tradition-formed use of a common instrument, not a separate language. The comparison is one of typical functions rather than absolute boxes: secular speech also performs, while religious discourse can assert facts.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "Religious language violates all ordinary logic, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. Religious language is a stretched, tradition-formed use of a common instrument, not a separate language. The comparison is one of typical functions rather than absolute boxes: secular speech also performs, while religious discourse can assert facts.

Examiner trap 17: Secular and religious speech share vocabulary and overlap in function.

MCQ 18. In Advaita, *neti neti* primarily functions as:

A. a theory that *māyā* is absolutely unreal, as the decisive criterion. B. univocal description of Brahman's properties, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference. C. the grammarian doctrine of a sentence-whole, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. D. eliminative negation of limiting identifications, not denial that Brahman is real, under the stated distinction.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "a theory that *māyā* is absolutely unreal, as the decisive criterion.". It fails the controlling distinction. *Neti neti* marks the limit of objectifying predicates. It removes finite conceptions so that Brahman is not treated as an object among objects. The danger is apparent self-reference; Advaita replies that negating language is pedagogical and itself sublated.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "univocal description of Brahman's properties, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference.". It fails the controlling distinction. *Neti neti* marks the limit of objectifying predicates. It removes finite conceptions so that Brahman is not treated as an object among objects. The danger is apparent self-reference; Advaita replies that negating language is pedagogical and itself sublated.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "the grammarian doctrine of a sentence-whole, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. *Neti neti* marks the limit of objectifying predicates. It removes finite conceptions so that Brahman is not treated as an object among objects. The danger is apparent self-reference; Advaita replies that negating language is pedagogical and itself sublated.
- **D:** Correct: *Neti neti* marks the limit of objectifying predicates. It removes finite conceptions so that Brahman is not treated as an object among objects. The danger is apparent self-reference; Advaita replies that negating language is pedagogical and itself sublated.

Examiner trap 18: *Neti neti* removes limiting predicates; it does not deny Brahman is real.

MCQ 19. What does *bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā* do in interpreting *tat tvam asi*?

A. It discards incompatible connotations and retains consciousness as the common import. B. It retains every literal connotation of both terms, under the theory's own terms. C. It proves that *tat* and *tvam* are entirely equivocal, for every form of religious discourse. D. It classifies Brahman as neither real nor unreal, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Also called *jahad-ajahal-lakṣaṇā*, this indirect indication sets aside omniscient causal and finite embodied standpoints while retaining their non-dual import. It is structurally comparable to analogy but belongs to Advaita's distinct pedagogical semantics.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "It retains every literal connotation of both terms, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. Also called *jahad-ajahal-lakṣaṇā*, this indirect indication sets aside omniscient causal and finite embodied standpoints while retaining their non-dual import. It is structurally comparable to analogy but belongs to Advaita's distinct pedagogical semantics.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "It proves that *tat* and *tvam* are entirely equivocal, for every form of religious discourse.". It fails the controlling distinction. Also called *jahad-ajahal-lakṣaṇā*, this indirect indication sets aside omniscient causal and finite embodied standpoints while retaining their non-dual import. It is structurally comparable to analogy but belongs to Advaita's distinct pedagogical semantics.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "It classifies Brahman as neither real nor unreal, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice.". It fails the controlling distinction. Also called *jahad-ajahal-lakṣaṇā*, this indirect indication sets aside omniscient causal and finite embodied standpoints while retaining their non-dual import. It is structurally comparable to analogy but belongs to Advaita's distinct pedagogical semantics.

Examiner trap 19: *Bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā* discards incompatible connotations and retains consciousness.

MCQ 20. The Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad offers a model of symbol leading beyond itself because:

A. it treats sound as a literal material creator, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike. B. it denies any connection between *Om* and consciousness, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice. C. it identifies *turīya* with one more empirical state, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. D. A-U-M maps waking, dream and deep sleep, while soundless *amātra* indicates *turīya* beyond articulated sound, while preserving its other speech functions.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "it treats sound as a literal material creator, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike." It fails the controlling distinction. The articulated symbol structures contemplation and becomes self-transcending at the soundless fourth. It is the clearest Indian example of symbolism as graded mediation rather than a finite object demanding literal worship.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "it denies any connection between *Om* and consciousness, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice." It fails the controlling distinction. The articulated symbol structures contemplation and becomes self-transcending at the soundless fourth. It is the clearest Indian example of symbolism as graded mediation rather than a finite object demanding literal worship.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "it identifies *turīya* with one more empirical state, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation." It fails the controlling distinction. The articulated symbol structures contemplation and becomes self-transcending at the soundless fourth. It is the clearest Indian example of symbolism as graded mediation rather than a finite object demanding literal worship.
- **D:** Correct: The articulated symbol structures contemplation and becomes self-transcending at the soundless fourth. It is the clearest Indian example of symbolism as graded mediation rather than a finite object demanding literal worship.

Examiner trap 20: *Om*kāra is a graded symbol; it does not prove every symbol causes mysticism.

MCQ 21. Which statement best expresses the pluralism bridge in religious language?

A. Pluralism follows automatically from any belief in God, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice. B. Analogical, symbolic or apophatic semantics can make rival descriptions partial and mode-relative, though not all contradictions disappear, while preserving its other speech functions. C. Univocal literalism always proves all religions true, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike. D. Non-cognitive language makes inter-religious disagreement impossible, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, in every context.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Pluralism follows automatically from any belief in God, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice." It fails the controlling distinction. Semantics shapes epistemic access and the status of rival claims. Non-literal approaches can soften personal/impersonal conflicts, but cannot dissolve hard existence-claims such as creator versus no creator or post-mortem survival versus extinction.
- **B:** Correct: Semantics shapes epistemic access and the status of rival claims. Non-literal approaches can soften personal/impersonal conflicts, but cannot dissolve hard existence-claims such as creator versus no creator or post-mortem survival versus extinction.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "Univocal literalism always proves all religions true, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike." It fails the controlling distinction. Semantics shapes epistemic access and the status of rival claims. Non-literal approaches can soften personal/impersonal conflicts, but cannot dissolve hard existence-claims such as creator versus no creator or post-mortem survival versus extinction.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "Non-cognitive language makes inter-religious disagreement impossible, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, in every context." It fails the controlling distinction. Semantics shapes epistemic access and the status of rival claims. Non-literal approaches can soften personal/impersonal conflicts, but cannot dissolve hard existence-claims such as creator versus no

creator or post-mortem survival versus extinction.

Examiner trap 21: The pluralism bridge is semantic but cannot erase existence-contradictions.

MCQ 22. Which Indian resource most directly marks standpoint-relativity inside propositions rather than merely declaring the ultimate unknowable?

A. Grammarian *sphoṭa*, under the theory's own terms. B. Advaita *neti neti* alone, under the theory's own terms. C. Jain *anekāntavāda* expressed through *syādvāda* and *saptabhaṅgī*, under the stated distinction. D. Mīmāṃsā *vidhi*, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Grammarian *sphoṭa*, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. The prefix *syāt* locates assertions "in a certain respect," enabling apparently conflicting claims to be assigned to different *nayas*. This is more determinate than simply retreating to an unknowable referent.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Advaita *neti neti* alone, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. The prefix *syāt* locates assertions "in a certain respect," enabling apparently conflicting claims to be assigned to different *nayas*. This is more determinate than simply retreating to an unknowable referent.
- **C:** Correct: The prefix *syāt* locates assertions "in a certain respect," enabling apparently conflicting claims to be assigned to different *nayas*. This is more determinate than simply retreating to an unknowable referent.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "Mīmāṃsā *vidhi*, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. The prefix *syāt* locates assertions "in a certain respect," enabling apparently conflicting claims to be assigned to different *nayas*. This is more determinate than simply retreating to an unknowable referent.

Examiner trap 22: Jain conditional predication states the respect; it does not license unconditional contradiction.

MCQ 23. With reference to Aquinas's divine predication, consider the following statements:

1. Pure perfections are present in God essentially and eminently.
2. The *modus significandi* derived from creatures adequately represents the divine mode.
3. "God is good" cannot be reduced to "God causes goodness."

Which of the statements given above are correct?

A. 1 and 3 only, while preserving its other speech functions. B. 1 and 2 only. C. 2 and 3 only, without qualification. D. 1, 2 and 3, as the decisive criterion.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: The perfection signified applies truly, but the creature-derived mode of signification is inadequate. Aquinas expressly rejects the cause-only paraphrase.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "1 and 2 only.". It fails the controlling distinction. The perfection signified applies truly, but the creature-derived mode of signification is inadequate. Aquinas expressly rejects the cause-only paraphrase.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "2 and 3 only, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. The perfection signified applies truly, but the creature-derived mode of signification is inadequate. Aquinas expressly rejects the cause-only paraphrase.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "1, 2 and 3, as the decisive criterion.". It fails the controlling distinction. The perfection signified applies truly, but the creature-derived mode of signification is inadequate. Aquinas expressly rejects the cause-only paraphrase.

Examiner trap 23: Hold pure perfection and inadequate creaturely signification together.

MCQ 24. Match List I with List II:

List I	List II
1. Ramsey	a. Self-involving language
2. Evans	b. Model and qualifier
3. Mīmāṃsā	c. <i>Vidhi</i> priority in disclosing <i>dharma</i>
4. Bhartṛhari	d. Classical <i>sphoṭa</i>

A. 1-a, 2-b, 3-d, 4-c. B. 1-b, 2-c, 3-a, 4-d, without qualification. C. 1-b, 2-a, 3-c, 4-d, while preserving its other speech functions. D. 1-c, 2-a, 3-d, 4-b, as the decisive criterion.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "1-a, 2-b, 3-d, 4-c.". It fails the controlling distinction. Ramsey supplies model-and-qualifier, Evans self-involvement, Mīmāṃsā the priority of injunction for *dharma*, and the grammarian Bhartṛhari the classical *sphoṭa* account.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "1-b, 2-c, 3-a, 4-d, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. Ramsey supplies model-and-qualifier, Evans self-involvement, Mīmāṃsā the priority of injunction for *dharma*, and the grammarian Bhartṛhari the classical *sphoṭa* account.
- **C:** Correct: Ramsey supplies model-and-qualifier, Evans self-involvement, Mīmāṃsā the priority of injunction for *dharma*, and the grammarian Bhartṛhari the classical *sphoṭa* account.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "1-c, 2-a, 3-d, 4-b, as the decisive criterion.". It fails the controlling distinction. Ramsey supplies model-and-qualifier, Evans self-involvement, Mīmāṃsā the priority of injunction for *dharma*, and the grammarian Bhartṛhari the classical *sphoṭa* account.

Examiner trap 24: Mīmāṃsā gives *vidhi* priority/śabda-nityatva; classical *sphoṭa* is principally Bhartṛhari.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 8**MCQ 25. A student writes, "Tillich's symbol is merely a convenient sign for an absent object." What is the best correction?**

A. Tillich treats every sign as sacred, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike. B. A Tillichian symbol participates in what it signifies and can disclose and transform; it is not merely conventional, with qualification. C. Tillich says symbols never die, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms. D. Tillich denies that symbols point beyond themselves, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Tillich treats every sign as sacred, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. The error removes Tillich's central mechanism. Participation, opening levels of reality/self, collective origin and mortality distinguish symbol from sign. A symbol still points beyond itself and must not absolutise its finite bearer.
- **B:** Correct: The error removes Tillich's central mechanism. Participation, opening levels of reality/self, collective origin and mortality distinguish symbol from sign. A symbol still points beyond itself and must not absolutise its finite bearer.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "Tillich says symbols never die, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. The error removes Tillich's central mechanism. Participation, opening levels of reality/self, collective origin and mortality distinguish symbol from sign. A symbol still points beyond itself and must not absolutise its finite bearer.

- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "Tillich denies that symbols point beyond themselves, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. The error removes Tillich's central mechanism. Participation, opening levels of reality/self, collective origin and mortality distinguish symbol from sign. A symbol still points beyond itself and must not absolutise its finite bearer.

Examiner trap 25: Tillich's symbol is not a convenient label; participation is the mechanism.

MCQ 26. Which correction should be made to the sentence "Scotus says God and creatures are ontologically beings in exactly the same way"?

A. Scotus rejects any common concept, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike. B. Scotus is defending Maimonidean negation, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, as the decisive criterion. C. Scotus defends semantic univocity of the concept, qualified by finite/infinite intrinsic modes, not identical ontological being, with qualification. D. Replace "Scotus" with "Ayer.", as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Scotus rejects any common concept, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. This is the highest-frequency univocity trap. The common concept protects inference; intrinsic modes protect the ontological gulf, and "being" is not treated as a genus containing God.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Scotus is defending Maimonidean negation, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, as the decisive criterion.". It fails the controlling distinction. This is the highest-frequency univocity trap. The common concept protects inference; intrinsic modes protect the ontological gulf, and "being" is not treated as a genus containing God.
- **C:** Correct: This is the highest-frequency univocity trap. The common concept protects inference; intrinsic modes protect the ontological gulf, and "being" is not treated as a genus containing God.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "Replace "Scotus" with "Ayer.", as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. This is the highest-frequency univocity trap. The common concept protects inference; intrinsic modes protect the ontological gulf, and "being" is not treated as a genus containing God.

Examiner trap 26: Scotist univocity is semantic; intrinsic modes preserve ontological difference.

MCQ 27. Which sentence correctly repairs the claim "Advaita calls Brahman anirvacanīya because Brahman is neither real nor unreal"?

A. *Māyā* is technically *anirvacanīya* as neither absolutely real nor unreal; Brahman is *sat* but beyond objectifying speech, under the stated distinction. B. Brahman is an empirically verifiable object, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. C. Advaita calls both Brahman and *māyā* unreal, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike. D. *Anirvacanīya* is a synonym for *sphoṭa*, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: The correction distinguishes ontological indeterminability from ineffability. Brahman defeats objectifying predication; *māyā* defeats classification under the real/unreal binary because it appears but is sublated.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Brahman is an empirically verifiable object, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. The correction distinguishes ontological indeterminability from ineffability. Brahman defeats objectifying predication; *māyā* defeats classification under the real/unreal binary because it appears but is sublated.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "Advaita calls both Brahman and *māyā* unreal, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. The correction distinguishes ontological indeterminability from ineffability. Brahman defeats objectifying predication; *māyā* defeats classification under the real/unreal binary because it appears but is sublated.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "*Anirvacanīya* is a synonym for *sphoṭa*, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. The correction distinguishes ontological indeterminability from ineffability. Brahman defeats objectifying predication; *māyā* defeats classification under the real/unreal binary because it appears but is sublated.

Examiner trap 27: Brahman is non-objectifiable but *sat*; *māyā* is technically *anirvacanīya*.

MCQ 28. A student attributes *sphoṭa* and *śabda-nityatva* together to Mīmāṃsā. What is the accurate repair?

A. Both belong exclusively to Nyāya, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment. B. Both belong exclusively to Advaita, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike. C. *Sphoṭa* belongs to Tillich and *śabda-nityatva* to Austin, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. D. Mīmāṃsā stresses *vidhi* and *śabda-nityatva*; *sphoṭa* is a grammarian doctrine associated with Bhartṛhari.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Both belong exclusively to Nyāya, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment.". It fails the controlling distinction. The distinction matters because the topic uses Mīmāṃsā to illustrate injunctive and liturgical function, not a generic Indian philosophy of language assembled from different schools.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Both belong exclusively to Advaita, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. The distinction matters because the topic uses Mīmāṃsā to illustrate injunctive and liturgical function, not a generic Indian philosophy of language assembled from different schools.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "*Sphoṭa* belongs to Tillich and *śabda-nityatva* to Austin, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. The distinction matters because the topic uses Mīmāṃsā to illustrate injunctive and liturgical function, not a generic Indian philosophy of language assembled from different schools.
- **D:** Correct: The distinction matters because the topic uses Mīmāṃsā to illustrate injunctive and liturgical function, not a generic Indian philosophy of language assembled from different schools.

Examiner trap 28: Do not attribute *sphoṭa* to Mīmāṃsā merely because both analyse language.

MCQ 29. In answering the 2024 20-mark question marked 10+10, which structure is mandatory?

A. Discuss only Braithwaite's biography, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without qualification. B. Allocate one balanced part to the cognitive/non-cognitive distinction and one to the alleged contradiction with Braithwaite's response, with qualification. C. Treat the marks split as optional metadata, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, in every context. D. Spend nearly the whole answer defining symbolism, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Discuss only Braithwaite's biography, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. Demand fidelity includes marks allocation. The second half must identify why factual meaning plus evidential immunity appears contradictory and decide whether analogical, defeasible cognitivism can avoid the problem.
- **B:** Correct: Demand fidelity includes marks allocation. The second half must identify why factual meaning plus evidential immunity appears contradictory and decide whether analogical, defeasible cognitivism can avoid the problem.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "Treat the marks split as optional metadata, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, in every context.". It fails the controlling distinction. Demand fidelity includes marks allocation. The second half must identify why factual meaning plus evidential immunity appears contradictory and decide whether analogical, defeasible cognitivism can avoid the problem.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "Spend nearly the whole answer defining symbolism, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. Demand fidelity includes marks allocation. The second half must identify why factual meaning plus evidential immunity appears contradictory and decide whether analogical, defeasible cognitivism can avoid the problem.

Examiner trap 29: The 2024 question is 10+10: distinguish first, then address contradiction.

MCQ 30. Which statement correctly distinguishes Hare and Mitchell?

A. Hare's *blik* is non-factual orientation; Mitchell's partisan models truth-apt, defeasible trust that acknowledges contrary evidence. B. Mitchell accepts Ayer's meaninglessness conclusion, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike. C. Both deny that religious commitments encounter counterevidence, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike. D. Hare proposes eschatological verification, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Their replies to Flew are not interchangeable. Hare saves significance by giving up ordinary factual vulnerability; Mitchell saves cognition by allowing adverse evidence to count without requiring immediate abandonment.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Mitchell accepts Ayer's meaninglessness conclusion, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. Their replies to Flew are not interchangeable. Hare saves significance by giving up ordinary factual vulnerability; Mitchell saves cognition by allowing adverse evidence to count without requiring immediate abandonment.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "Both deny that religious commitments encounter counterevidence, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. Their replies to Flew are not interchangeable. Hare saves significance by giving up ordinary factual vulnerability; Mitchell saves cognition by allowing adverse evidence to count without requiring immediate abandonment.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "Hare proposes eschatological verification, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling

distinction. Their replies to Flew are not interchangeable. Hare saves significance by giving up ordinary factual vulnerability; Mitchell saves cognition by allowing adverse evidence to count without requiring immediate abandonment.

Examiner trap 30: Hare's blik ignores counterevidence as factual; Mitchell concedes it counts.

MCQ 31. Which claim about symbolism and mysticism is most defensible?

A. Every symbol necessarily culminates in unmediated experience, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification. B. Only Western traditions use symbols as graded practices, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, as the decisive criterion. C. Symbolism is a normal but non-necessary route; it may be transcended, may arrest in idolatry, or may constitutively shape experience, with qualification. D. Mysticism and symbolism are unrelated, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Every symbol necessarily culminates in unmediated experience, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. The answer combines Tillich's participatory route, the idolatry/demonic warning, Indian *Om* and *upāsanā*, and Katz's constructivism. It avoids both automatic progression and total disconnection.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Only Western traditions use symbols as graded practices, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, as the decisive criterion.". It fails the controlling distinction. The answer combines Tillich's participatory route, the idolatry/demonic warning, Indian *Om* and *upāsanā*, and Katz's constructivism. It avoids both automatic progression and total disconnection.
- **C:** Correct: The answer combines Tillich's participatory route, the idolatry/demonic warning, Indian *Om* and *upāsanā*, and Katz's constructivism. It avoids both automatic progression and total disconnection.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "Mysticism and symbolism are unrelated, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice.". It fails the controlling distinction. The answer combines Tillich's participatory route, the idolatry/demonic warning, Indian *Om* and *upāsanā*, and Katz's constructivism. It avoids both automatic progression and total disconnection.

Examiner trap 31: Symbolism is normal but non-necessary; idolatry, Katz and iconoclasm block inevitability.

MCQ 32. Which factual statement is safest in a high-scoring answer?

A. Tillich's non-symbolic exception remained unchanged and uncontested, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference. B. Non-literal semantics dissolves every conflict between religions, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment. C. D. Z. Phillips straightforwardly accepted the label "non-cognitivist.", while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification. D. Phillips rejected reductionist labelling; Tillich's exception is disputed; and some inter-religious existence-claims remain hard contradictions, under the stated distinction.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Tillich's non-symbolic exception remained unchanged and uncontested, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference.". It fails the controlling distinction. The option combines three attribution cautions. Precision earns marks: do not force Phillips into a box, do not present Tillich's evolving exception as settled, and do not turn semantic humility into indiscriminate harmonisation.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Non-literal semantics dissolves every conflict between religions, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment.". It fails the controlling distinction. The option combines three attribution cautions. Precision earns marks: do not force Phillips into a box, do not present Tillich's evolving exception as settled, and do not turn semantic humility into indiscriminate harmonisation.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "D. Z. Phillips straightforwardly accepted the label "non-cognitivist.", while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification.". It fails the controlling

distinction. The option combines three attribution cautions. Precision earns marks: do not force Phillips into a box, do not present Tillich's evolving exception as settled, and do not turn semantic humility into indiscriminate harmonisation.

- **D:** Correct: The option combines three attribution cautions. Precision earns marks: do not force Phillips into a box, do not present Tillich's evolving exception as settled, and do not turn semantic humility into indiscriminate harmonisation.

Examiner trap 32: Tillich modified the exception, and Phillips resisted reductionist classification.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQS - 14 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

Exact wording and marks are controlled by the verified 2018-2025 Philosophy of Religion ledger.

PYQ 1 - 2018 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

Exact verified question: In what sense is the secular use of language different from the religious use of language? Discuss.

Demand decoding: "In what sense" requires named axes plus continuity; do not hunt for a sacred vocabulary.

Model solution: Religious and secular discourse largely share words such as "father," "light" and "knowledge"; their difference is primarily one of **function, referent, verification and self-involvement**. Secular sentences commonly describe or predict publicly identifiable states. Religious utterances may also worship, confess, bless or vow. Austin's performative analysis explains why "I take refuge in the Buddha" enacts commitment, while Evans calls such speech self-involving.

Reference also differs: religious predicates concern transcendence, so Ramsey's ordinary **model** plus stretching **qualifier** explains non-literal disclosure. Verification may be experiential or eschatological rather than immediately observational. Yet the contrast is not absolute: scripture can contain historical assertions, and secular oaths are performative.

Religious language is therefore a tradition-formed, symbolically stretched and characteristically committing use of ordinary language-not a separate vocabulary or a licence to abandon logic.

Why this earns marks: It states the "use, not vocabulary" thesis, names the axes, links examples to analysis and qualifies the contrast.

PYQ 2 - 2018 · Q7(b) · 15 marks

Exact verified question: Critically examine Braithwaite's non-cognitive theory of religious language.

Demand decoding: Reconstruct the moral-conative view before testing reductionism; distinguish Ayer, Hare and Wittgenstein.

Model solution: Braithwaite's *An Empiricist's View of the Nature of Religious Belief* (1955) accepts that unverifiable theology cannot function like an ordinary empirical hypothesis but rejects Ayer's conclusion that religion is meaningless. A religious assertion principally declares commitment to a **moral policy**, sustained by stories. "God is love" avows an **agapeistic** way of life; narrative supplies models and motivation.

The theory explains why creed and conduct are connected and why religious language is self-involving. Austin and Evans support this practical insight: utterances can commit and constitute relationships rather than merely report facts.

Its weakness is reductionism. Believers normally intend both moral commitment and a claim about reality. Removing the latter produces an "atheist's account of religion"; a secular humanist could adopt agape without the creed. Nor are lament, prayer, creation, resurrection and mystical negation all moral policies. Hare's *blik* and Wittgensteinian grammar cannot simply be folded into Braithwaite.

Braithwaite may reply that practice is the publicly intelligible core. That preserves significance but not assertoric intention. His account is best retained within a mixed speech-act theory: religious utterances can be moral-commissive and truth-apt.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs Braithwaite fairly, distinguishes adjacent non-cognitivism, evaluates believer intent and ends with a defended mixed verdict.

PYQ 3 - 2018 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

Exact verified question: Explain the significance of religious symbols as transcendent referent that mediates into the cultural, spatial and temporal world.

Demand decoding: Explain mediation across all three demanded dimensions; Tillich's participation is central.

Model solution: A religious symbol is a finite bearer through which a community apprehends transcendence. Its significance lies in **mediation**: it makes a non-ostensible referent culturally intelligible, spatially encounterable and temporally repeatable without identifying the bearer with the ultimate.

Tillich distinguishes symbol from sign. A sign points conventionally; a symbol **participates**, opens levels of reality and self, transforms the participant, arises collectively and can die. Thus cross, temple, sacred narrative or *Om* can mediate ultimate concern.

Culturally, symbols embody myths, ethics and memory; Ricoeur's "the symbol gives rise to thought" marks interpretive surplus. Spatially, Eliade's **hierophany** turns a place or object into sacred orientation, enabling worship and pilgrimage. Temporally, festivals and liturgy re-present an originating event to later generations.

The danger is arrest: a finite bearer claiming ultimacy becomes idolatrous or **demonic**. Conversely, a wholly indeterminate symbol loses reference. Symbols are bridges, not photographs: valid when they disclose and point beyond themselves, criticisable when they conceal or absolutise their cultural form.

Why this earns marks: It explains the mechanism, covers cultural/spatial/temporal mediation and qualifies disclosure through idolatry and vague-reference controls.

PYQ 4 - 2019 · Q6(a) · 20 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss whether and how does religious symbolism lead to mysticism.

Demand decoding: Answer both "whether" and "how": route the mechanism, then give the negative case.

Model solution: Religious symbolism can lead to mysticism when a finite symbol mediates participation and then becomes transparent to what it signifies. It is neither necessary nor guaranteed: symbols may arrest consciousness, and constructivists deny that experience ever escapes mediation.

How the route works. Tillich's symbol participates and opens levels of reality and self. Contemplative use draws the practitioner beyond information toward involvement. Ricoeur's "symbol gives rise to thought" describes the interpretive beginning; his second naïvete permits post-critical re-inhabitation. Pseudo-Dionysius gives the sequence: cataphatic names are affirmed, then negated apophatically, culminating in mystical unknowing.

Indian materials make the graded mechanism precise. Symbol or image worship (*pratīka/pratimā upāsana*) can prepare movement from qualified (*saguṇa*) devotion to the unqualified (*nirguṇa*). In the *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad*, A-U-M corresponds to waking, dream and deep sleep; the soundless fourth (*amātra, turīya*) is the culmination beyond articulated sound. Mantra and diagram (*yantra*) may be internalised and dissolved.

Why it may fail. Literalisation makes the symbol idolatrous or demonic. Katz argues that symbols constitute mystical experience rather than lead to an unmediated terminus. Zen iconoclasm and *neti neti* delete images; ethics, inquiry and grace are alternative routes.

Symbolism is therefore a normal but non-necessary path, successful only when participatory practice is joined to self-effacement.

Why this earns marks: It fulfils both directives, links named evidence to the four-stage route and includes arrest, constructivism and non-necessity.

PYQ 5 - 2020 · Q8(a) · 20 marks

Exact verified question: Does religious language carry cognitive content? Elucidate in detail.

Demand decoding: Give a defended spectrum, empirical objections, non-cognitive accounts and a mixed conclusion.

Model solution: Religious language carries cognitive content when utterances purport to state what is true or false of reality, but its cognition is rarely crude literal description. A sentence can be assertoric, analogical or symbolic, expressive and performative at once.

The realist case begins with believer intention. Aquinas holds that a perfection's **thing signified** (*res significata*) applies truly while the creaturely **mode of signification** (*modus significandi*) remains inadequate. Tillich's symbolic realism claims participation in being-itself; Ramsey's model-and-qualifier preserves continuity. Hick's celestial-city parable makes an assertion truth-apt now though possibly verified only eschatologically.

Ayer challenges this through verification. Flew asks what could count against divine love; endless qualification may empty content. Hare replies with a life-shaping *blik*, while Mitchell's partisan protects cognition by admitting adverse evidence counts.

Braithwaite reads belief as an agapeistic moral policy. Wittgensteinian approaches locate meaning in grammar and form of life; Phillips resisted a simple non-cognitivist label. Austin and Evans show that confession, blessing and vow enact commitments.

The cost of pure non-cognitivism is reductionism; the cost of literalism is anthropomorphism and evidential immunity. A mixed account is strongest: defeasible truth-claims signified analogically or symbolically and joined to expressive or commissive acts.

Why this earns marks: It maps the spectrum, attaches named evidence to each claim and defends a position that preserves realism and critical vulnerability.

PYQ 6 - 2021 · Q8(a) · 20 marks

Exact verified question: What is non-cognitive theory of religious language? Explain critically in the light of R. B. Braithwaite's views.

Demand decoding: Define the family, state Braithwaite's version and evaluate it against believer intent.

Model solution: A non-cognitive theory denies that factual description is the primary or valid function of religious language. The family is diverse: Ayer calls unverifiable theology meaningless; Hare's *blik* is an unfalsifiable orientation; Wittgensteinian approaches study grammar and use. Braithwaite offers a specifically **moral-conative** account.

In *An Empiricist's View of the Nature of Religious Belief* (1955), Braithwaite interprets "God is love" as a declaration of intention to follow an **agapeistic policy**. Religious stories sustain that commitment through exemplary patterns; their practical role need not depend on ordinary empirical verification. The theory saves meaning from Ayer and explains the bond between creed and conduct.

Its strengths are self-involvement and practical seriousness. Yet it mistakes an important illocutionary force for total semantic content. Believers generally mean that God exists and loves, not only that they intend to love. If stories disclose nothing real, their distinctive authority becomes unclear; a secular person can adopt agape. Prayer, lament, resurrection and apophatic speech also resist reduction to one policy.

Braithwaite differs from Hare's world-picture and from Phillips, who denied reducing grammar to attitude. Mitchell and Hick preserve truth-aptness while widening evidential standards.

Thus Braithwaite supplies valuable pragmatics but inadequate total semantics. A mixed account should retain moral commitment, analogical or symbolic assertion and vulnerability to reasons.

Why this earns marks: It defines the family, locates Braithwaite precisely, develops distinct objections and preserves his insight in a better theory.

PYQ 7 - 2021 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

Exact verified question: Explain the symbolic nature of religious language with special reference to Paul Tillich.

Demand decoding: Explain Tillich's criteria, being-itself and dangers; preserve the disputed exception.

Model solution: Tillich calls religious language symbolic because ultimate concern cannot be captured as one finite object. A symbol is not decorative metaphor or conventional sign. It points beyond itself while **participating** in what it indicates, opens levels of reality and self, grows from collective life, transforms participants and can die.

Accordingly, "Father," cross or sacred narrative mediates ultimate concern rather than literally classifying God as a magnified being. God is not the highest being but **being-itself**. Literalising a finite bearer makes it ultimate and therefore idolatrous; Tillich calls this distortion **demonic**.

The theory respects transcendence while explaining existential force and cultural plurality. Its weakness is referential vagueness: what exactly does participation mean? Tillich treated "God is being-itself" as a non-symbolic anchor, but later modified the position; its status is disputed.

Aquinas provides a contrast: analogy stresses ordered semantic content through causal participation, whereas Tillich stresses existential disclosure. Symbolic language is meaningful and potentially cognitive only when its referent and communal criteria remain disciplined and the symbol points beyond, rather than demands worship for, its finite form.

Why this earns marks: It gives Tillich's full mechanism and ontology, qualifies the exception and tests symbolic realism through a precise comparator.

PYQ 8 - 2022 · Q5(e) · 10 marks

Exact verified question: Explain the difference between the cognitivist and non-cognitivist approaches to the religious language with reference to the statement - "God exists".

Demand decoding: Apply both accounts directly to "God exists"; distinguish truth-aptness from practical force.

Model solution: The distinction concerns whether "God exists" states something true or false. A **cognitivist** treats it as an assertion about reality. Aquinas preserves reference analogically; Hick treats the claim as truth-apt now and possibly verified eschatologically. Cognitivism matches believer intention but faces Ayer's verification challenge and Flew's demand for counterevidence.

A **non-cognitivist** relocates meaning. Braithwaite hears commitment to an agapeistic policy; Hare treats belief as a life-shaping *blik*; Wittgensteinian approaches examine its grammar in worship and hope, though Phillips rejected simple reductionism. Ayer's hostile version calls it meaningless.

These accounts need not exhaust one another. "God exists" can assert reality, use analogical or symbolic predicates, express trust and commit conduct. The most adequate analysis is mixed: practical force supplements rather than cancels cognitive intent.

Why this earns marks: It applies every distinction to the stated sentence, separates semantic mode from truth-status and adjudicates with a clear mixed position.

PYQ 9 - 2023 · Q5(d) · 10 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss Wittgenstein's view about the non-cognitive nature of religious language.

Demand decoding: Explain meaning-as-use and Last Judgement, then qualify the non-cognitive attribution.

Model solution: Wittgenstein's lectures shift attention from an isolated sentence's empirical test to its **use** in religious life. Belief in the Last Judgement does not function merely as a forecast like tomorrow's weather; it organises repentance, hope, fear and conduct. Later Wittgensteinian approaches express this through language-game, grammar and form of life.

The view is called non-cognitive because it resists treating prayer or belief as detached scientific hypothesis. Yet the label is contested. Wittgenstein offered no single reductive theory, and D. Z. Phillips denied that clarifying religious grammar made beliefs fictional or meaningless.

Its strength is contextual accuracy; its risk is fideistic insulation if internal use makes external evidence irrelevant. Mitchell's defeasible trust supplies a corrective. Wittgensteinian analysis therefore shows that religious meaning exceeds description, not that every religious claim lacks cognitive content.

Why this earns marks: It explains use and form of life through the correct example, protects attribution discipline and answers the insulation objection.

PYQ 10 - 2023 · Q7(c) · 15 marks

Exact verified question: Explain the symbolic nature of religious language according to Tillich.

Demand decoding: Reconstruct participation, disclosure and being-itself; test reference and idolatry.

Model solution: For Tillich, religious language is symbolic because finite literal concepts cannot contain ultimate concern. A sign points by convention and is replaceable; a symbol points beyond itself while **participating**, opens reality and self, arises collectively, transforms and may grow or die.

Names such as Father, Kingdom or cross therefore mediate rather than photograph transcendence. God is not a being within the totality but **being-itself**. This prevents anthropomorphic literalism and explains existential transformation. It also explains distortion: when a conditioned image claims unconditional validity, it becomes idolatrous or **demonic**.

The account preserves positive language without reducing God to an object. Yet participation is obscure and can make reference vague. If all God-talk is symbolic, the assertion that it is symbolic appears to need a non-symbolic basis. Tillich proposed "God is being-itself" as that basis, but later modified the position; its coherence remains disputed.

Aquinas' analogy clarifies the difference: causal participation orders perfection-terms, while Tillich stresses existential disclosure. Tillich shows how non-literal language can be meaningful, but symbolic realism remains defensible only where interpretation is constrained and the symbol stays self-transcending.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs all central Tillichian claims, uses analogy as a discriminator and gives a qualified referential verdict.

PYQ 11 - 2024 · Q5(e) · 10 marks

Exact verified question: Explain the analogical nature of religious language.

Demand decoding: Frame the dilemma, state Aquinas's mechanism, example, objection and verdict.

Model solution: Aquinas uses analogy to avoid two failures. Univocal predication makes God a finite member of a shared category; complete equivocity makes God-talk unintelligible. Analogy preserves ordered similarity-with-difference.

Pure perfections such as goodness exist in God **essentially and eminently**. Their **thing signified** (*res significata*) applies truly, while the creature-derived **mode of signification** (*modus significandi*) remains inadequate. Later Thomists distinguish attribution-"healthy" said primarily of an animal and derivatively of medicine-from proportionality, where goodness belongs according to divine and creaturely modes. This taxonomy is especially Cajetanian, not Aquinas's fixed formula.

Scotus objects that inference needs a univocal concept; Aquinas replies that causal participation supplies continuity without placing God in a genus. Analogy therefore secures realist meaning without literal anthropomorphism, though its standing cost is indeterminacy.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing dilemma, uses the exact technical pair and taxonomy caution, and answers the strongest rival.

PYQ 12 - 2024 · Q8(a) · 20 marks (10+10)

Exact verified question: Distinguish between cognitivist and non-cognitivist account of religious language. Does the cognitivist account lead to any contradiction? Answer with reference to the philosophical views of R. B. Braithwaite.

Demand decoding: Respect the 10+10 split: distinguish first; then assess the alleged contradiction and Braithwaite's solution.

Model solution: Part I - distinction. Cognitivism treats "God exists" or "God is good" as truth-apt. Aquinas preserves reference analogically; Mitchell treats faith as defeasible trust; Hick allows eschatological verification. Non-cognitivism denies that fact-stating is primary or legitimate, but includes Ayer's meaninglessness, Hare's *blik*, Wittgensteinian use and Braithwaite's moral-conative account.

Braithwaite interprets "God is love" as commitment to an **agapeistic policy** sustained by stories. Cognitivism asks what reality the statement describes; Braithwaite asks what conduct its avowal commits one to. These may be dimensions of one utterance rather than exclusive meanings.

Part II - contradiction assessed. The pressure appears when a believer claims divine love factually while allowing no suffering to count against it. Flew's invisible gardener shows how endless qualifications preserve words but remove evidential content; Ayer adds the verification problem. This is not a formal contradiction inherent in cognitivism but a danger of **evidential immunity**.

Braithwaite avoids it by relocating meaning to policy, but believers ordinarily intend a claim about God, and agape can be adopted without theology. His analysis cannot exhaust prayer, resurrection, lament or negation.

Mitchell offers a better middle: commitment survives ambiguity while adverse evidence genuinely counts. A mixed account can preserve analogical or symbolic assertion, moral commitment and defeasibility. Cognitivism becomes contradictory only when truth-claim is combined with total evidential invulnerability.

Why this earns marks: It obeys the marks split, identifies evidential immunity rather than inventing formal contradiction, and evaluates Braithwaite directly.

PYQ 13 - 2025 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Exact verified question: Is religious language symbolic? Give reasons and justification in support of your answer.

Demand decoding: Take a position, rank reasons through Tillich, and qualify symbolic mode against total non-cognitivism.

Model solution: Religious language is characteristically symbolic because transcendence cannot be presented as one finite observable object; but symbolic mode does not mean absence of cognitive intent.

Tillich's symbol differs from a sign: it **participates**, opens levels of reality and self, transforms, arises collectively and can die. "Father," light or cross mediates ultimate concern rather than literally classifying God. God is not one being among others but being-itself; an absolutised finite symbol becomes idolatrous or demonic.

Symbols also explain existential force and cultural plurality. The *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad* makes *Om* a graded symbol whose soundless fourth points beyond articulated sound.

Yet participation can be vague, and prayers, vows and assertions have different forces. Tillich's disputed being-itself exception shows the need for referential discipline. Religious language is substantially symbolic in mode, while often retaining assertoric and performative dimensions.

Why this earns marks: It gives a ranked yes-but case, uses Tillich and the *Māṇḍūkya* example, and preserves mixed speech functions.

PYQ 14 - 2025 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the Advaitic notion of indescribability (anirvacanīyatā) in the context of nature of religious language.

Demand decoding: Treat anirvacanīyatā as predication; distinguish māyā from Brahman and explain negation, indication and sublation.

Model solution: Advaita distinguishes two linguistic limits. Brahman is beyond objectifying speech-ineffable or *avācya*-whereas **anirvacanīya** *technically characterises* māyā*, ignorance and world-appearance as neither absolutely real nor unreal.

The world appears and has transactional validity, so it is not unreal like a hare's horn; it is sublated by knowledge of Brahman, so it is not ultimately real. It is therefore *sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa* and defeats binary classification. Brahman, by contrast, is *sat* and non-objectifiable; it is not indeterminable in *māyā*'s sense.

Language still has a disciplined role. "Not this, not this" (*neti neti*; Bṛhadāraṇyaka 2.3.6) removes limiting predicates. "Whence words turn back" (*yaṭo vāco nivartante*; Taittirīya 2.9) marks objectification's limit. Indirect indication (*lakṣaṇā*) preserves intended import: in *tat tvam asi*, *bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā* discards incompatible connotations and retains consciousness.

The self-reference objection says that calling Brahman indescribable describes it. Advaita replies that such language is therapeutic: like one thorn removing another, it removes error and is itself sublated. Advaitic religious language is eliminative and indicative, not mere silence or emotivism.

Why this earns marks: It preserves the decisive Brahman/māyā distinction, explains each semantic operation and answers self-reference with sublation.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE - 6 MODELS

These are original learner-practice questions, not UPSC PYQs.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: "Analogy protects transcendence only by sacrificing intelligibility." Examine with reference to Aquinas and Scotus. (Answer within 150 words.)

Demand decoding: Test the quotation through Aquinas's mechanism, Scotus's objection and a graded verdict.

Model answer: The charge identifies analogy's risk but overstates its failure. Aquinas rejects anthropomorphic univocity and empty equivocity. Pure perfection exists in God essentially and eminently: the *res significata* applies truly, while creaturely *modus significandi* remains inadequate. Causal participation supplies ordered continuity.

Scotus objects that inference requires a semantically univocal concept of being; otherwise analogy disguises equivocation. His certain-and-doubtful argument allows one to be certain that God is a being while doubtful whether finite or infinite. Intrinsic modes restore ontological difference.

The Thomist reply is that causal dependence, not a common genus, grounds the middle term. Yet analogy must explain how its proportion is fixed. It preserves **qualified intelligibility**, not transparency. A defensible conclusion combines analogical predication, enough conceptual continuity for inference, and an apophatic limit on adequacy.

Why this earns marks: It converts the quotation into the inference/transcendence trade-off, gives Scotus's strongest argument and reaches a qualified synthesis.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Can religious utterances be performative without ceasing to be cognitive? Discuss. (Answer within 150 words.)

Demand decoding: Separate illocutionary force from truth-aptness and use concrete speech acts.

Model answer: Yes. "Performative" concerns what an utterance does; "cognitive" concerns whether it also expresses a truth-apt proposition. The dimensions need not conflict.

Austin distinguishes locutionary content from illocutionary force. "I take refuge in the Buddha," baptism, vow or ritual resolve (*saṃkalpa*) performs an act under appropriate conditions. Evans calls such speech self-involving because it

commits conduct and constitutes relationships.

These acts carry presuppositions: prayer normally presupposes an addressee; thanksgiving a benefactor; baptism a community and authority. "God is love" may assert something while committing the speaker to agape. Braithwaite captures commitment but reduces assertion.

A mixed speech-act account is therefore preferable. Religious language can be assertoric, symbolic and commissive together, provided practical commitment does not become immunity from evidence or criticism.

Why this earns marks: It separates truth-aptness from force, uses concrete evidence and states the condition under which performance remains cognitive.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Compare the via negativa of Maimonides with Advaita's *neti neti*. Do they end in meaningful discourse or silence? (Answer within 250 words.)

Demand decoding: Compare grounds, permitted speech and self-reference; include action-attributes and *lakṣaṇā*.

Model answer: Maimonides and Advaita use negation to prevent finite predicates from objectifying the ultimate, but neither begins or ends with mute scepticism.

In *Guide for the Perplexed* 1.50-60, Maimonides denies positive essential attributes because they compromise divine simplicity. Legitimate speech consists of **negations**-God is not ignorant-and **attributes of action**-God is called merciful from effects rather than a creature-like quality. Negation removes error while action-language sustains ethical discourse.

Advaita's "not this, not this" (*neti neti*; Bṛhadāraṇyaka 2.3.6) removes limiting identifications. Brahman remains *sat*, not nothing. Advaita also supplies indirect indication (*lakṣaṇā*): in *tat tvam asi*, *bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā* discards incompatible connotations and retains consciousness.

Both face vacuity and self-reference: "the ultimate is indescribable" seems descriptive. Maimonides answers through determinate negations and effects; Advaita treats language as a thorn removing ignorance, itself sublated after knowledge.

They end in disciplined silence, not meaninglessness. Their termini differ: Maimonides preserves Creator-creature distance; Advaita culminates in non-dual recognition.

Why this earns marks: It compares metaphysical grounds and permitted speech, answers self-reference and directly adjudicates the silence question.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: "The meaning of religious language is exhausted neither by truth-conditions nor by use." Critically discuss. (Answer within 250 words.)

Demand decoding: Show what truth-condition and use theories explain and defend a mixed account.

Model answer: The statement is persuasive because religious discourse is heterogeneous. Truth-conditions matter where believers assert that God exists or liberation is possible; use matters where they pray, vow, confess or orient a life.

Cognitivism preserves believer intent. Aquinas shows that truth-aptness need not mean univocal literalism: the perfection signified applies while the creaturely mode remains inadequate. Hick and Mitchell preserve truth through possible verification and defeasible trust. Yet truth-conditions alone under-describe illocutionary force.

Austin and Evans show that utterances act and involve the speaker. Ramsey explains disclosure through model and qualifier; Mīmāṃsā's injunction (*vidhi*) and mantra reveal practical organisation. Wittgensteinian grammar makes these uses intelligible within a form of life.

Use alone is insufficient. Braithwaite's agapeistic policy captures commitment but omits the intended claim about God. Phillips therefore resisted reductionist non-cognitivism. Internal grammar also cannot make external evidence or moral criticism irrelevant.

A mixed account is strongest: identify proposition, semantic mode, illocutionary force and practice together. Religious utterances may be assertoric, analogical, symbolic, expressive and commissive without one dimension exhausting the others.

Why this earns marks: It states each theory's gain and cost, uses named evidence analytically and defends an integrated semantics/pragmatics verdict.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: Develop and defend a mixed account of religious language against both verificationist elimination and fideistic insulation. (*Answer within 350 words.*)

Demand decoding: Construct a positive account, answer both errors, integrate Indian resources and state a defeater.

Model answer: A defensible theory must preserve four facts: believers intend assertions; transcendent reference exceeds literal description; utterances also worship and commit; and claims remain answerable to reasons. A **mixed account** analyses proposition, semantic mode, speech act and practice together.

Against verificationist elimination, Ayer wrongly equates factual meaning with present empirical testability. Aquinas shows how analogical predication can remain truth-apt; Hick's eschatological verification distinguishes present evidence from verification in principle. Flew's challenge remains valuable: a cognitive claim must acknowledge what counts against it. Mitchell's partisan models defeasible trust rather than immunity.

Against fideistic insulation, Wittgensteinian grammar correctly explains why Last Judgement belief is not merely a forecast. But internal use cannot make a practice self-validating; Phillips himself rejected crude reductionism. Religious language overlaps with public moral and factual life.

Speech-act analysis supplies the synthesis. Austin distinguishes locution from illocution; Evans shows self-involvement. "God is love" can assert analogically, express trust and commit agape. Tillich adds symbolic participation; Ramsey adds model and qualifier.

Indian materials confirm functional plurality. Advaita uses eliminative negation (*neti neti*) and indirect indication (*lakṣaṇā*); Mīmāṃsā gives injunction priority without making every sentence imperative; Jain conditional predication states the respect.

The account's defeater would be proof that no religious utterance genuinely intends reference, or that every proposed referent is semantically empty. Short of that, mixed realism best preserves meaning, practice and critical vulnerability.

Why this earns marks: It constructs rather than merely surveys a theory, answers both opposing failures, integrates Indian mechanisms and states a genuine defeater.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: How does a theory of religious language shape the possibility of religious pluralism? Critically examine. (*Answer within 350 words.*)

Demand decoding: Trace semantics to rival truth-claims, compare Hick, Advaita and Jainism, then preserve hard contradictions.

Model answer: Religious pluralism is downstream of religious semantics. How traditions speak about ultimate reality determines whether rival claims are direct contradictions, partial descriptions or incommensurable practices.

If God-talk is univocal and literal, descriptions are directly comparable: "a personal creator exists" and "no personal creator exists" cannot both be true in the same respect. Exclusivism follows naturally unless one claim is rejected. If language is analogical, symbolic or apophatic, finite formulations need not exhaust their referent; plural descriptions may be mode-relative without truth becoming relative.

Hick makes this bridge explicit. The Real *an sich* is transcategorical, while traditions experience personal and non-personal **personae/impersonae** through cultural schemes. Remove that limit-of-predication thesis and his pluralism collapses. Yet it inherits the apophatic objection: a Real of which nothing substantial is said may be indistinguishable from nothing.

Advaita provides two-level semantics: Brahman without qualities (*nirguṇa*) exceeds predication while with-qualities (*saguṇa*) forms structure devotion. Jain many-sidedness and conditional predication (*anekāntavāda*, *syādvāda*) specify the standpoint within the proposition, avoiding a retreat to unknowability. R̥gveda 1.164.46 supplies one referent/many names, but its inter-religious extension requires argument.

The limit is decisive. Non-literal semantics can route personal/non-personal descriptions but cannot dissolve creator/no-creator or survival/no-survival. A viable semantic pluralism combines non-exhaustive reference, specified

standpoints and acknowledgement of hard contradiction. It makes pluralism intelligible, not automatically true.

Why this earns marks: It traces a causal conceptual chain, uses three distinct models, states their objections and preserves the hard-contradiction boundary.

Question-shaped timed-paper compression plan

Demand	Protect	Cut first
Secular vs religious use	function/referent/self-involvement	long examples
Braithwaite	policy + stories + reductionism	minor comparators
Symbol mediation	participation + three dimensions	surplus illustrations
Symbol -> mysticism	mechanism + negative case	one secondary tradition
Cognitive content	spectrum + Flew/Mitchell + verdict	minor representatives
Tillich	sign/symbol + being-itself + caution	historical detail
Analogy	dilemma + res/modus + Scotus	extra comparisons
Advaita	Brahman/māyā + neti/lakṣaṇā	extended parity

Independence note

All explanations, model answers and marks rationales are independent learner material. UPSC publishes no official model answers for these questions.